

Munich, and the *patatnik* pie of Bulgaria's Rhodope mountains. Seville's refreshing cold salad soup, gazpacho, was born with the landing of New World peppers and sweet tomatoes. Few New World plants had the transformative impact of the tomato, so perfectly matched to mozzarella cheese, fragrant basil, and fulsome olive oil in Capri's *insalata caprese*. Mount the same ingredients on a thin bread crust – but with the tomato strained and lightly cooked – and the combination becomes Naples' pizza Margherita, a dish that now graces tables across the globe.

Changing Traditions

Many culinary traditions of Europe embrace the same informality as pizza. Spanish tapas are often eaten with the fingers or skewered with a toothpick. The bite-sized meze of Istanbul reprise the old Ottoman empire, from the stuffed vine leaves called dolmades (shared with the cuisine of Greece) to the eggplant salads, little meatballs, white cheese, and sliced melons of the far reaches of Asia Minor. The twin themes of bounty and hospitality underpin such a feast – concepts echoed far to the north with the Swedish

smorgasbord buffet and its dishes of herring, eel, meatballs, potato casseroles, sliced meats, and fat sausages.

Traditionally, Europeans are the world's great meat-eaters. Feasts can be as rustic as a Toulouse cassoulet of pork, sausages, and beans or Burgundy's braised beef stew, or as ceremonial as the roast haunch of beef with all the trimmings that's key to the identity of the English. Similarly, few Greeks would give up their roast Easter lamb – nor the *Madriños* their mixed *cocido* hotpot, the Berliners their hearty braised pork knuckle, or the Alsations the tangy pickled vegetables and rich sausages of their *choucroute garnie*. No German worth his or her salt would pass up the spicy pot roast known as sauerbraten, while any Scot worth a tartan feasts on haggis every Burns Night.

But Europeans also love to turn tradition on its head. English pub cooks have transformed the leaden repasts of yesteryear into the bright, fresh-ingredient cooking of the gastropubs. The master chefs of Spain's San Sebastián married inventive genius with Basque traditions to revolutionize fine dining in Spain – and, by example, across Europe and the Americas.

Creative genius applies to European sweets as well, from pistachio and honey confections like Anatolian baklava to the elaborate torten of Salzburg, from the simple cream-filled *pasteis de nata* of Lisbon to the textural perfection and simple grace of a Parisian *macaron* delicately filled with a chocolate ganache. In Europe, the French say it best: *Bon appétit!*

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Left Cakes and pastries were raised to the level of an art form in the patisseries of France
Below A restaurant terrace in Vernazza on the Cinque Terre coastline of Italy

